

Activity 4: Plan a Singapore-Japan Distribution Partnership

TSC mapping: K2 | K3 | A2 | A3 Objective: Adapt process, communication and team roles for a cross-cultural distribution negotiation without relying on stereotypes. Expected output: A culturally adaptive negotiation plan that clearly separates verified facts from hypotheses. Primary source: <https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/negotiation-skills-daily/types-of-negotiation-skills/>

Goal

Prepare a Singapore health-food producer to meet a Japanese distributor about territory, forecasts, brand control and launch support.

Real-world scenario

Real-world use case: international distribution negotiations may differ in communication, consensus, pacing, hierarchy and relationship-building. Individual behaviour must be verified rather than inferred from nationality.

Merlion Nutrition wants a three-year Japanese distribution agreement. The prospective distributor has requested a senior executive meeting before discussing price. Merlion's founder prefers fast decisions; the distributor has circulated technical questions to several departments and has not named the final approver.

Evidence boundary

The business setting is a realistic composite. Numerical and organisational inputs created for practice are labelled as training assumptions and must not be presented as real company facts.

Training assumptions / guardrails

- Merlion can allocate one senior sponsor and one bilingual adviser.
- Product registration will take an estimated four to six months.
- The distributor seeks exclusivity but has not committed to minimum annual volume.
- Both parties agree that all binding terms will be confirmed in English and Japanese versions reviewed by counsel.

Questions

1. Which cultural observations are facts, and which are hypotheses to test?
2. What respectful process questions should clarify authority and consensus?
3. How should the agenda balance relationship-building and commercial progress?
4. What safeguards prevent ambiguity across language versions?

Detailed activity procedure

Step 1: Separate evidence and hypothesis

Create two columns: observed behaviour or stated process, and possible interpretations requiring verification.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 2: Map decision process

Ask how recommendations, technical review, executive approval and legal confirmation occur.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 3: Adapt team composition

Assign sponsor, lead, technical expert, bilingual adviser and recorder with clear speaking roles.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 4: Design the agenda

Sequence introductions, purpose, market strategy, interests, technical questions, commercial packages and next steps.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 5: Plan communication checks

Use summaries, written issue logs, translation review and explicit confirmation of provisional versus agreed items.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Step 6: Stress-test exclusivity

Link territory rights to minimum performance, reporting, review and exit provisions.

Checkpoint: Record the evidence, calculation or decision produced in this step.

Deliverable

A culturally adaptive negotiation plan that clearly separates verified facts from hypotheses.

Acceptance criteria

The plan contains at least five verification questions, a clear authority path and no unsupported statement that treats culture as destiny.

Reflection and debrief questions

1. Which assumption changed your negotiation plan most, and why?
2. What evidence would you request before relying on the result?
3. Which stakeholder owns the next decision or approval?
4. What would you repeat or change in the next negotiation?

Source note

Source accessed 15 August 2026:

<https://www.pon.harvard.edu/daily/negotiation-skills-daily/types-of-negotiation-skills/>